a trial basis. The guns were found to be suitable, only needing a few modifications to cater for the high altitude and rarefied atmosphere. I had a word with Mr JD Patil, the MD of L&T Defence, who readily agreed to carry out these modifications at no cost. The upshot was that two Regiments were inducted into the Sector and an order for 100 more guns was placed. This was the advantage of having an indigenous weapons system, on which modifications could be carried out without reference to any foreign vendor. However, apart from these exceptions, the rebalancing was mainly in terms of a change of roles. There was little or no physical relocation as such. Most of these formations were earlier earmarked for the Western Front and dual-tasked for the Eastern Front. Now, the roles had been reversed. Should a contingency arise, they would still be available to deal with a threat from Pakistan, which was now at a lower priority. Periodic re-evaluations of the threat perception would continue in the future and readjustments carried out as necessary.

Though still inadequate, the increase in force ratios on the Northern Front will definitely make the PLA think twice before embarking on any misadventure, especially now that we have the offensive capability to take the battle into Chinese territory. In our posture against China, we have moved up from dissuasive deterrence (defensive) to credible deterrence (offensive defence). With these developments, the PLA must have realized that a military solution to the border problem is improbable. The time is thus ripe for a resumption of the SR-level talks to settle the border question.[12] Pending the settlement of the boundary dispute, which is likely to be time-consuming, articulation of a 'non-aggression' pact between the two countries would go a long way in restoring confidence, paving the way for de-escalation and de-induction of forces

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